Selling solar in Vermont after the tax credit

The 30% homeowner credit is gone, paybacks have stretched, and the whole state's solar numbers are down. People are still spending money on energy, though. They're spending it on lower heating bills, backup power, and someone to look after the panels they already own. This plan covers the website first, then six ways to find those buyers before other installers do. Each one rests on public data and systems work, not on advice you could find online.

WEBSITE: HARVESTARPOWER.COM CHECKED 29 OCT 2026 PUBLIC INFORMATION ONLY

The market you're selling into now

-27% Small (0–15 kW) solar permits in Vermont, 2025 vs 2024: 1,971 down to 1,431 (PUC data)	**-33%** Further drop in permit filings in Q1 2026 vs Q1 2025 (Renewable Energy Vermont)	**14 → 20 yrs** Payback on a typical 10 kW system without the credit, by SunCommon's own figures to the Legislature
~3,400 Homes in Lincoln, Bristol, Starksboro, Monkton and New Haven heating with oil or propane (Census, 2020–24)	**20,000+** Vermont households that already net-meter. None of the work they need depends on a tax credit	**12/31/2027** Last day for a lease, PPA or business-owned system to be in service and still carry the 30% federal credit

Some things went the other way. From August 2026 the PUC raised net-metering credit for new systems to **$0.1571/kWh**, GMP rates went up **5.5%** in October, and the PUC itself now says new solar "cannot provide a benefit unless paired with a battery." Heat pump rebates from Efficiency Vermont continue in 2026: up to **$2,200** for ducted systems and **$600** for heat pump water heaters. The money hasn't left; it's moved to different products.

What the PUC records already show for your five home towns

Before writing this I pulled every net-metering case the Public Utility Commission has on file for Lincoln, Bristol, Starksboro, Monkton and New Haven. That's 1,221 filings covering 856 solar sites. Think of it as a small version of Play 1 below, and it's already useful:

0 of 28 2026 solar filings in those five towns that list Harvestar. In 2024 you had 14 of 68, second only to SunCommon	**35 → 23 → 10** Harvestar filings statewide, January to October, in 2024, 2025 and 2026	**173** Different customers who've listed Harvestar as their installer since 2017. Every one of them could refer you
103 Sites whose installer has left Vermont or gone bankrupt (Sunrun, SolarCity, iSun, Freedom Forever)	**+39** More sites whose installer looks inactive, including 15 put in by a Bristol company that no longer seems to operate	**371** Systems first filed 2009–2016. They're now 10–17 years old: the age when inverters fail and warranties have run out

Local filings fell from 68 to 28 over two years, so the whole market shrank. But it didn't disappear. The 28 jobs filed in 2026 went to Building Energy, Solar Zack, SunCommon and Team Sunshine, while your own work moved to Charlotte, Middlebury and the Mad River Valley. That isn't a criticism. It shows the work near home exists and someone is getting it. Behind these numbers is a list of each site's address, installer, size, age and whether it's owned or leased. It's ready to become a mailing list as soon as we agree how to use it.

Notes: filing dates are close to, but not the same as, install dates. Sunrun no longer lists Vermont among its states but still owns its leased systems here. The same pull works for any Vermont town.

Part 1 · The website

I went through all 42 pages in the sitemap on desktop and phone, checked 104 links, and looked at how Harvestar shows up on Google, Yelp, MapQuest and the directories. Here's what's working first, because a lot is.

Eric's credentials

The About page bio (NABCEP, BPI, Vermont heating license) is the strongest trust signal on the site.

Heat pumps and audits are already offered

The services the market is moving toward are already on the menu. They just aren't what the site leads with.

Real job photos

Drone shots of named customer arrays beat stock photos by a mile.

The technical basics work

HTTPS, a responsive layout, quick load (about 2 MB), up-to-date plugins and a working contact form.

What's costing you leads, most important first

01 **The site still sells with incentives that no longer exist.** The solar page says the system "is eligible for a 26% federal tax credit." About says "up to 40%" in incentives and VSECU financing. Spring 2015 solar hot water offers ("SAVE $4,500") are still live and in Google.

Fix: rewrite the solar pitch around what pays now (the net-metering rate, batteries with GMP's incentive, heat pumps with Efficiency Vermont rebates) and remove or redirect the expired offers.

02 **No working analytics for over three years.** The only tracking tag is Google's old Universal Analytics, which Google shut off in July 2023. There's no GA4, no call tracking and no form tracking.

Fix: GA4 plus call and form tracking. Until it's there you can't tell whether a slow month is the site or the market.

03 **The phone number can't be tapped on a phone.** There's no click-to-call link anywhere, and a setting in the page header stops iPhones adding one automatically. Pinch-zoom is turned off too.

Fix: a sticky "Call (802) 444-4900 · Book a site visit" bar on mobile. It's a few minutes of work and recovers calls straight away.

04 **Reviews are thin, and the visible one is negative.** The only public review I could find is a 1-star Yelp review on an unclaimed listing. There's no Google rating I could find and no BBB or EnergySage listing, and the newest testimonial on the site is from 2020.

Fix: a review-request routine for past customers (see Play 6). Years of happy customers are an asset you aren't using yet.

05 **Invisible in local searches.** Harvestar didn't show up for "solar installer Addison County VT", "heat pump installer Bristol VT" or "solar Middlebury VT." NuWatt Energy ranks with a page per town and 2026 incentive guides, and Bristol Electronics shows up too. Harvestar has no town pages, no business details marked up for Google, no main headline on the homepage, and image descriptions that are just file names.

Fix: town pages for the core service area, local business markup, and proper headings and image descriptions.

06 **Directories disagree about the business.** MapQuest and Yelp-sourced listings show 802-458-5405 instead of 444-4900. Some say Bristol and some Lincoln, and one aggregator even marks the business closed. LinkedIn lists the industry as "Renewable Energy Semiconductor Manufacturing."

Fix: claim and correct the Google, Yelp and Bing listings and the main aggregators, so everything shows one name, address and phone.

07 **The offer and form are dated.** There's no "get a quote" button near the top of the homepage. The homepage calculator is for solar hot water, which also lost its federal credit. The form doesn't ask for town or a rough electric bill, and three old pages show a public "CAPTCHA plugin is not active" warning.

Fix: one clear "free site visit" offer, a better form, and the calculator from Play 3.

08 **Pages that make the business look abandoned.** There's a Lorem ipsum page, an empty "High Performance Homes" page, a contact page that's just a note to the webmaster, and three broken links on the Products page. About still says "7 years" of experience. The newest news post is from April 2022.

> THE SHORT VERSION
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> Items 1, 3, 6 and 8 are a few days of cleanup. Items 2, 4 and 5 take a month to set up and then run on their own. All of that is necessary, but none of it fixes the market by itself. Part 2 is about that.

Part 2 · Six ways to grow, without the tax credit

Each of these depends on public data, automation or analysis that takes real build work. That's why most installers won't do them, and why they work.

01

Map every solar system around Lincoln and become the area's solar mechanic

BIGGEST OPPORTUNITY | NO TAX CREDIT NEEDED | RECURRING REVENUE

Every net-metered system in Vermont is registered with the Public Utility Commission, with its town, installer, size and date. The five-town version is already done (page 2). We'd extend it to Middlebury and out to about 20 miles and match them to property records. You get a map and list of every system, sorted into groups:

- **Orphaned systems:** the installer has closed or left Vermont, so the workmanship warranty went with them.
- **Inverters near end of life:** string inverters from 2012–2016 are now 10–14 years old, which is around when they fail.
- **Solar but no battery:** the obvious next buyer for backup power.
- **Your own past customers.**

Then we'd build a **Solar Checkup** service on top of it: a fixed-price visit checking production against what that roof should make, plus inverter, roof penetrations and snow damage. You'd get a branded health report you generate on site from your checklist and photos, an optional yearly membership, and a booking page. Every checkup is a warm lead for an inverter, a battery or a heat pump.

Why you can't just google it: the records sit in the PUC's ePUC case system, one case at a time. Turning them into a clean, sorted list takes scripted collection, matching against land records, and checking which installers still exist.

02

Find the oil and propane homes and sell them heat pumps with real numbers

LARGEST POOL | REBATES STILL LIVE

In Bristol 80% of homes heat with oil or propane. In Monkton, Lincoln and New Haven it's 62–69%. In the five core towns that's roughly 3,400 households. The federal heat pump credit also ended, but Efficiency Vermont's rebates continue, and the enhanced weatherization incentives (up to 90%) run only **through the end of 2026**.

We'd combine Census heating data, the state's roof-by-roof solar layer and the town property lists to build a scored list of owner-occupied homes, most likely buyers first. Each gets a mailer with a QR code to a page for their own address, showing honest savings after rebates. Responses are tracked by town and by mailing so you know what worked. We'd start with a test of 500–1,000 pieces.

Why you can't just google it: heating fuel isn't in the property records. Picking likely oil homes means combining three public datasets and scoring every address.

03

An honest-numbers calculator and proposal tool

TRUST ADVANTAGE | WEBSITE + KITCHEN TABLE

Most solar calculators online still include the 30%, or use Vermont rates from before August 2026. Homeowners who know the credit ended assume solar "doesn't work anymore." We'd build one tool, branded Harvestar and used on the website and in your quotes, that compares side by side:

- buying solar outright, at the new $0.1571/kWh net-metering rate
- a no-money-down lease or PPA (Play 4)
- solar plus a battery you own, with GMP's battery incentive, vs leasing GMP's Powerwalls
- heat pump plus heat pump water heater, with the solar sized to the new electric load

It works from that address's roof data and shows 10-year cash flow and the effect on the bill. It produces a PDF proposal, and every web lead goes into your list with the numbers attached. We'd keep the numbers updated as Efficiency Vermont and the PUC change them.

04

The 30% isn't fully gone, but it ends 12/31/2027

DEADLINE | ABOUT 14 MONTHS

The federal 48E credit still covers solar **owned by a business or by a leasing company**, as long as it's in service by 12/31/2027. That opens two doors:

- **Leases and PPAs for homeowners.** At least one national financier (Palmetto LightReach) lists GMP and VEC territory as active, and its credit is built into the customer's price. We'd vet the options (fees, escalators, equipment rules, the customer experience) and give you a plain comparison so you can decide whether to offer one.
- **Farms and local businesses.** 30% credit plus depreciation (their accountant confirms), plus a USDA REAP grant under the new October 2026 rule, which pays after the project is built and measured. We'd build the farm and business prospect list from parcel data, a bill-analysis template, and a REAP document pack.

Behind both: a pipeline board planned backwards from the deadline (last date to sell, to file, to install) so nothing slips into 2028.

05

Battery outreach that fires itself after every outage

AUTOMATED | TIMED TO NEED

The PUC cut GMP's line-burial plan to about a third of what GMP asked for, so rural outages will keep coming. We'd watch the outage feeds for your towns. When a long outage hits, a ready-made "stay powered next time" postcard or email goes to the solar-but-no-battery homes from Play 1 in those towns, while people still remember sitting in the dark. Your angle against GMP's leased Powerwalls is ownership, and backup designed to keep the heat pump and well pump running.

The same system watches the PUC's net-metering rewrite (opened September 2026) and sends you a plain-English note when anything changes that affects what you can tell customers.

06

Turn past customers into reviews and referrals

CHEAPEST LEADS | QUICK TO START

Every past Harvestar customer gets a yearly "your solar year" note covering production, savings and a health check, pulled from their monitoring where possible. Each one includes a referral offer and a one-tap Google review link, plus an automatic review request after every new job. Combined with the listing cleanup in Part 1, this turns one 1-star review into a page of real ones. In a county this size, reputation is what sets you apart.

How we'd work together

You keep doing the installs; we build and run the systems that find the jobs. This is a suggested order, and it starts with the things that have deadlines.

MONTH 1

Fix and fill

- Website cleanup: incentives, tap-to-call, placeholders
- GA4 + call and form tracking
- Google and directory listings corrected
- Past-customer review and referral run
- Lease/PPA partner comparison

MONTHS 2–3

Build the map

- Installed-system map and lists (Play 1)
- Solar Checkup offer, booking page and report tool
- Honest-numbers calculator (Play 3)
- Heat pump test mailing before the 2026 weatherization deadline

MONTHS 3–6

Run and refine

- Farm and business pipeline to 12/31/2027
- Outage-triggered battery campaign live before winter
- Town pages for local search
- Monthly one-page report: leads, sources, jobs

A GOOD FIRST CONVERSATION

Roughly how many systems you've installed, what you'd most like to sell more of, and how many jobs a month you can take on. That decides which plays come first and how big to make the mailings.

Before we promise anything, we confirm:

- that GMP's bring-your-own-battery incentive is still taking new customers (one report said it was approved only through September 2026; GMP's page still lists it)
- whether the PUC will supply net-metering records in bulk, or whether we collect them case by case
- whether lease/PPA financiers accept a small Vermont installer as a partner, and on what terms

Sources: harvestarpower.com (all pages, 29 Oct 2026); Vermont PUC Order 26-0291-INV (29 May 2026) and rulemaking notice (9 Sep 2026); Renewable Energy Vermont and SunCommon testimony to the Vermont Legislature (2026); IRS guidance on the 2025 tax law (25D, 25C, 48E); Efficiency Vermont 2026 rebates; Green Mountain Power program pages; Vermont Public (GMP rate case, Sep 2026); USDA REAP final rule (91 FR 62600); US Census ACS 2020–24 (table B25040); VCGI parcel and rooftop solar data; Yelp, MapQuest and LinkedIn listings. This is a summary, not tax advice; customers should confirm tax treatment with their accountant.

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